AI Shotgun Style

A Sum of the Parts

An open forum on what AI can and can't do for you

Tim Gustafson · SmartPlay AI



Veteran Owned and Developed

Not a sales pitch



Open forum

Your questions drive the night. No question is too basic.



No jargon

Plain language. Terms get named only after you have seen the thing.



Your goal

Nothing for sale. The goal is for you to hit yours.

It started with my yardage



A resume

Someone said AI could help review it. First time using AI.



A website

The next night it helped build a site for my own company.



A golf course

I just wanted my yardage. No app felt intuitive.



An app

That question became SmartPlay Caddie.

“Wait, what else can this do?”

Where I started: zero tech

4

years Marine Corps

6

years Army medic and radiology tech

26

years in medical imaging

0

software background

Everything since was self-taught, with AI as the leverage.

Show the weapon, fully assembled

Late April

first build

Sep 17

live on the App Store and Google Play

1.0 → 1.0.4

Caddie versions since

21

projects built

~4,500

saved changes

LIVE: the commercial · Caddie · the Lean Canvas advisor

One question became a portfolio

GOLF

Caddie
AI caddie, on both app stores

Bay
AI lessons in simulator bays

Play
Golf game in the browser

LIFE AND WORK

SmartManage
Life manager with Roger

SmartPump
Fitness and training

SmartMotion
Camera motion analysis

Inner Library
Personalized books

GAMES

Gridiron Life
Football career

Mayor of the Lake
Run Lake Elsinore

Save the AMX
Rescue a carmaker

IN THE LAB

Defender
Guards your AI and inbox

Studio
Scripts to finished video

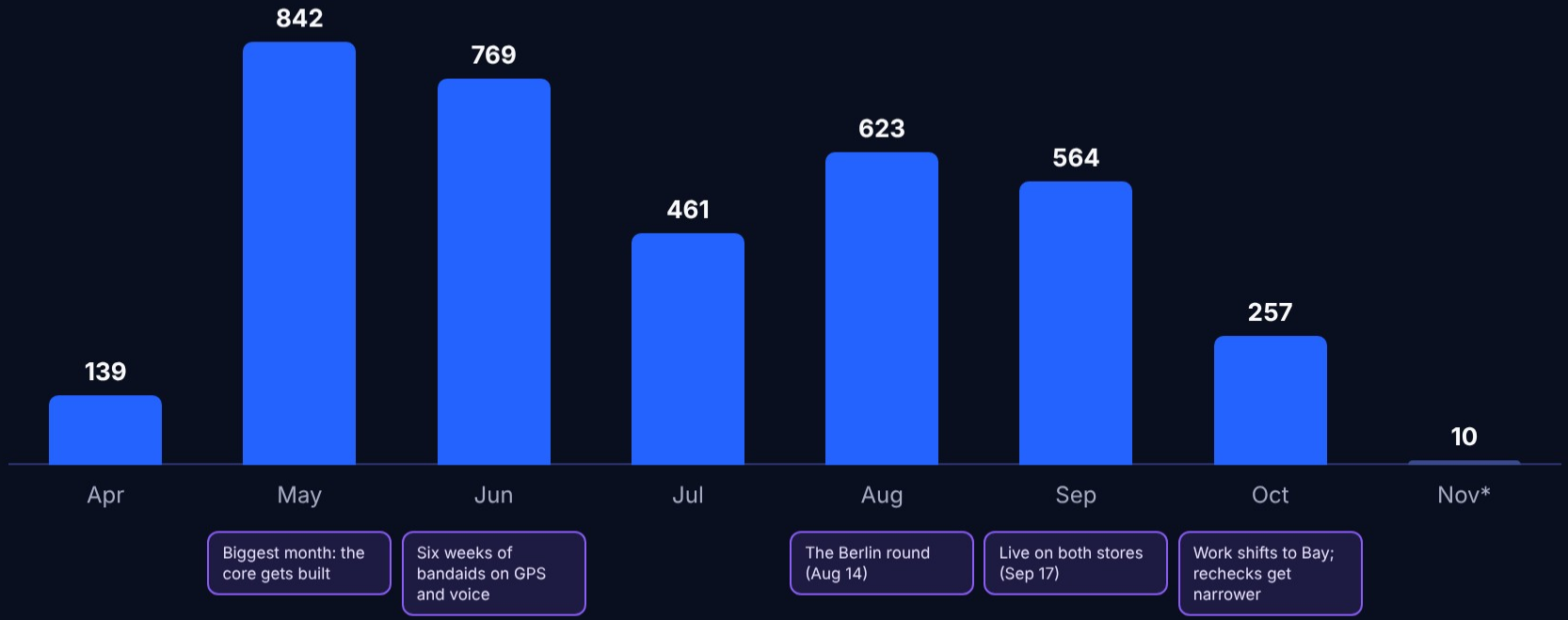
Rondo
Coaching platform

PlaySmart
Learning for kids

Whatever you want to build, we have probably built something like it.

The work curve: Caddie, month by month

Saved changes to the Caddie app each month, 2026 · about 3,665 in total



Source: git history of the Caddie app. *November through Nov 4

Why "just ask the chatbot" falls short

General chatbot

You ask ▶ It knows nothing about you ▶ General answer ▶ You rewrite it yourself

...and around the loop again

Built for you

You talk it through ▶ It already knows your context ▶ Focused answer, with pushback ▶ **Written into your work**

Field strip: the parts of an AI tool

BOLT

Brain

Does the thinking and decides

BOLT CARRIER

Orchestrator

Routes each request to the right tool

BUTTSTOCK

Memory

Braced against you: knows your work

MAGAZINE

Inputs

Your words, files and data

BARREL

Voice

How it talks back to you

SIGHTS

The mission

One clear job, not "ask me anything"

SAFETY

Security gate

Checks before anything fires

TRIGGER

You

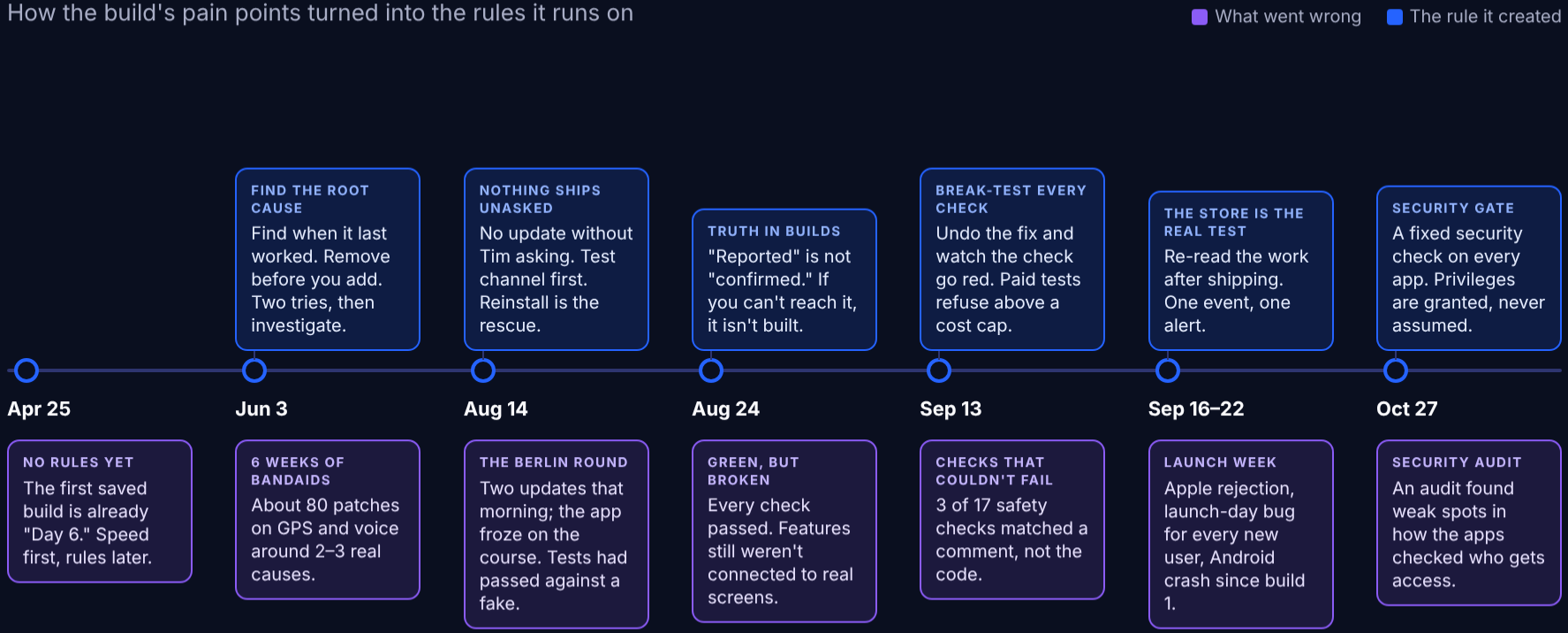
Nothing happens without your call

Common malfunctions I hit

MALFUNCTION	WHAT HAPPENED	LESSON
The Berlin round	Two updates the morning of a round; the app froze on the course	**Trust the person using it over the theory**
Six weeks of bandaids	Patched GPS and voice symptoms around 2–3 real causes	**Name the root cause before fixing**
Built, not connected	Features worked in code but could not be reached on screen	**If you can't reach it, it isn't built**
Apple rejection	Wrong permission screen; reviewer could not find the subscriptions	**Design for a first-time user**
Unlimited AI bill	Spending limit was $200,000 with auto-reload; cut to $100 a month	**Set spending limits on day one**

Every rule was paid for

How the build's pain points turned into the rules it runs on



Source: SmartPlay repo history and rule files, Apr–Nov 2026

How the checks stacked up

Each layer was added after the one below it let something slip through

In progress	**Self-heal in every app**	Apps find and report their own problems; target Nov 15
Oct 28	**Recheck until dry**	A recheck that finds problems means another round
Oct 27	**Shared security gate on every app**	Fixed rules, no AI deciding pass or fail
Sep 13	**Every check is break-tested**	Undo the fix; the check must go red
Aug 24	**Truth rules: verified vs. reported**	Every result says what was actually checked
By August	**Paid AI test runs, with a spending cap**	Real calls to the AI; they refuse to run above $1.50
By August	**Simulated rounds and cost checks**	Play a round without a golf course; watch the AI bill
From the start	**Automated tests and type checks**	Catch broken code before it ships

The lesson

A green check is not a working product. Every layer exists because the one below it said "pass" while something was still broken.

PAIN → RULE → CHECK

Build the check from the failure, then prove the check can fail.

Source: SmartPlay repo rule files and audit, Nov 2026

Immediate-action drills

1. Find when it last worked before fixing anything
2. Removing a broken part beats adding a patch
3. Two failed fixes, then stop and investigate
4. Trust the user's real-world report over the theory
5. Nothing ships until you ask for it

How Tim uses AI

One founder, a digital staff: what runs on its own, what it connects to, and where it's going

8 recurring jobs · **12** connected tools · **21** projects built · **0** things sent without Tim

The schedule

RUNS ON ITS OWN · PACIFIC TIME

Daily 6:58 AM	**Imaging leads**	Finds verified 1099 and $175K+ imaging roles, drafts outreach emails, logs to Drive
Daily 6:59 AM	**Caddie Instagram post**	One ready-to-post idea: hook, caption, hashtags, image from the Mac
7:45 AM + 5:45 PM	**App error triage**	Reads crash reports, separates real golfers from reviewers, finds the cause, writes the fix prompt
Daily 7:45 PM	**Promo thread check**	Reddit and Product Hunt replies sorted into bugs, requests and praise, with draft replies
Nightly 8:37 PM	**QC audit, one app a night**	Secrets, dependencies, tests, live sites and databases checked; every app every week
Mondays 6:31 AM	**Outreach, traffic and SEO**	Local events and creators, Military Monday promo, email drafts, 4-site traffic, SEO, LinkedIn
Sundays 8:13 PM	**Done-work load**	The week's commits and wins logged in SmartManage so Roger stays current
Sundays 8:47 PM	**Command Center refresh**	New jobs and pages filed; to-dos from the week's chats added to SmartManage
One-time	**Reminders**	Nov 12 Caddie 2.0 avatars · Nov 13 code and key cleanup · Dec 15 Apple trial decision



What AI does for the business

PROCESSES, NOT CHAT

Build Apps and tools
Caddie on both app stores, Bay, Play, SmartManage, SmartPump, three games and more, built with Claude Code. Kevin and Roger run on Claude.

Protect Quality and security
Nightly audits, twice-daily error triage, a shared security gate on every app, break-tested checks.

Grow Marketing
Instagram posts, outreach and creator lists, Military Monday promo, YouTube channel and videos, traffic, SEO, LinkedIn.

Run The business
Investor deck, websites, store listings, docs, class decks, a filed media library on the Desktop.

Career Imaging work
Daily verified leads with outreach drafted and logged.

Life Admin
To-dos into SmartManage, emails drafted, files organized, research done and sourced.

Tuned Optimizations
AI spend capped at $100/month with an alert at $50; paid test runs refuse above $1.50. A fast, cheap model handles quick routing and a stronger one does the real thinking. Alerts fire only when there's something to act on, and everything lands in one dashboard.

Guardrails on every job

- Draft or read-only: Tim posts, sends and approves
- No guessing: every fact checked that run, or marked "not shown"
- Every job ends with a clear success test
- Short, numbered output with yes/no decisions

Future state

- **Nov 15** · every app reports its own problems (self-heal v1)
- **Dec 1** · Defender on the phone: send it a suspicious email or text, get the intent check
- **Jan 2027** · fixes drafted automatically; one tap to approve; shipped and rolled back automatically
- **Before Jan 2027** · Kevin's voice cloned and owned, before the current voice is retired
- **Roger 2.0 and Aiva** · a real conversational assistant, plus an AI board (strategy, business development, finance)
- **All inboxes in SmartManage** · every email account in one place, no reconnecting
- **Creation Engine** · Studio first: scripts, videos, worlds and characters from one engine
- **Ideas in the queue** · a bug-fix agent across all apps, a peer-review analyzer, viewer questions by text or email

Source: Tim's scheduled tasks, connectors and project notes, as of Nov 5, 2026

Function check: your task list

What my digital staff does now

- Drafts emails into my outbox
- Files to-dos into my task app
- Researches and checks sources
- Builds decks, docs and websites
- Writes video scripts and outreach

Your turn

1. Pick one admin or marketing task that eats your time
2. Say how you want it done
3. We run it live and see what AI gets right and wrong

I review and send. AI drafts.

What AI can and can't do

CAN

- Draft, summarize and rewrite fast
- Research and organize information
- Handle repetitive admin and marketing
- Help you build your own tools

CAN'T

- Know your business unless you give it context
- Guarantee facts: you still verify
- Make your decisions for you
- Protect your data unless you set it up to

Everything tonight was built with AI

- **Interactive Lean Canvas**
  with an advisor that talks you through it
- **Class plan, invite and RSVP**
  drafted to my outbox, I hit send
- **Build history**
  read from about 4,500 saved changes
- **This deck**
  slides, graphics and speaker notes
- **The build-story video**
  cut from the app's own old screenshots
- **A media page and a filed library**
  120+ files sorted, duplicates cleared

In three days, between class sessions. One person.

What do you want to build?

After action review: what worked, what didn't, and your questions. Your question might be our next episode.

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SmartPlay AI · Veteran Owned and Developed · Let's build.

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